Translation: Reading XI: The Human Fetus

Source: Hasenfratz & Jambeck, "Reading Old Englixh: A Primer and First Reader (Revised Edition)", University of West Virginia Press, 2011, p. 352

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Hēr on-ginð secgan ymbe mannes ġe-cynde hū hē on his mōdor innoþe tō man ġe-wyrðeð. Ǣrest þæs mannes bræġen bið ġe-worden on his mōder innoþe, þonne bið þæt bræġen ūtan mid rēoman bewefen on þǣre syxtan wucan. On ōðrum mōnþe þā ǣdran bēoð ġe-worden, on lxv ond þrēo hundred[1] scytran ond lengran[2] hī bēoð tō-dǣlede ond þæt blōd þonne flōweð on þā fēt ond uppan þā handa, ond hē þonne byþ on limum tō-dǣled ond tō-somne ġearwað. On þām þriddum mōnþe hē bið man būtan sāwle. On þām feorþan mōnþe hē bið on limum staþol-fæst. On þām fiftan mōnþe hē biþ cwica ond weaxeð, ond sēo modor līð witlēas[3] ond þonne þā ribb bēoð ġe-worden, þonne ġe-limpð þǣr maniġ-feald sār þonne þæs byrþres līċ on hire innoþe scypiġende bið. On þām syxtan mōnþe hē byþ ġe-hȳd ond bān weaxende. On þām seofoþan mōnþe þā tān ond þā fingras bēoð weaxende. On þām eahtoþan mōnþe him bēoð þā brēost-þing weaxende ond heorte ond blōd ond hē bið eall staþol-fæstlīċe ġe-seted. On þām niġoþan mōnþe witodlīċe wīfum[4] bið cūð hwæþer hī cennan magon. On þām tēoþan mōnþe þæt wīf ne ġe-dīgð hyre feore ġif þæt bearn ā-cenned ne biþ, for þām þe hit in þām magan wyrð hire[5] tō feorh-ādle, oftost on Tīwes-niht[6].

Here [we] begin to tell about [a] human being's birth how he in his mother's womb becomes a person. First the man's brain is developed in his mother's womb, then the brain is covered over on the outside with [a] membrane in the sixth week. In another month the veins are developed, into three hundred and sixty five shorter and longer they are divided and the blood then flows into the feet and up to the hands, and he then is divided into limbs and prepares [them] together. In the third month he is [a] man without [a] soul. In the fourth month he is firm in limbs. In the fifth month he is alive and grows, and the mother lies witless and then the ribs are developed, then happens there manifold pains when the fetus' body in her womb is forming. In the sixth month he is furnished with skin and bone is growing. In the seventh month the toes and the fingers are growing. In the eighth month the breasts are growing [the chest is growing?] on him and heart and blood and he is entirely firmly established. In the ninth month, in truth, [it] is revealed to the women whether they are able to give birth. In the tenth month the woman will not survive [with] her life if that child is not given birth to, because it in the womb comes as [a] fatal disease unto her, most often on Monday night.

[1] *lxv ond þrēo hundred* — 365

[2] *scytran ond lengran* — Isaac: comparatives are *always* weak. I had these as positive adjectives, but the glossary (look at the glossary, Chris) marked them as comparatives. Mainly what we should look for here is: is there a preceeding article, demonstrative or possessive, but the adjective is still weakly conjugated? Then this is a comparative. (in the book, pp. 183-184, section 6.5).

[3] *modor līð witlēas* — Read this as a prescription to stay in bed; bedrest.

[4] *wīfum* — wīfum depends on cūð

[5] *hire* — This is the "ethical dative" so "unto her"

[6] *Tīwes-niht* — This really means "the night before Tuesday" because biblically, the next day begins at sundown of the previous day, just like the Sabbath begins on Friday at sundown and ends on Saturday at sundown.

About this text

The following excerpt comes from one of several Anglo-Saxon medical texts. For a discussion of medical lore in Anglo-Saxon England, see Stephanie Hollis's article "Scientific and Medical Writings" in _A Companion to Anglo-Saxon Literature_ (Eds. Phillip Pulsiano and ElaineTreharne. Oxford: Blackwell, 2001, pp. 188-208.

Glossary

Parts of Speech

n: noun

v: verb

adj: adjective

pron: pronoun

det: determiner

adv: adverb

conj: conjunction

prep: preposition

int: interjection

num: numeral

Gender & Case

m: masculine

f: feminine

n: neuter

n: nominative

a: accusative

g: genitive

d: dative

i: instrumental

Verb Notation I

pa: past

pr: present

i: indicative

s: subjunctive

imp: imperative

Verb Notation II

f: finite

i: infinitive

p: participle

ii: inflected infinitive

1: 1st person

2: 2nd person

3: 3rd person

s: singular

pl: plural

Adjective & Adverb

Adj/Adv Degree

p: pos

c: comp

s: sup

Adj Inflection

s: strong

w: weak

How to Decode Annotations

Codes in [brackets] after attested forms encode morphology using the abbreviations listed above.

ā-cennan v: *weak1* gave birth to; **ā-cenned** [ppa]

ædre n: *f weak* artery; a vein; fountain; river; nerve; sinew; kidney; **ædran** *veins* [np]

ǣrest adv: first; **ǣrest** [p]

bān n: *n strong* bone; **bān** [ns]

bearn n: *n strong* child; **bearn** [ns]

bēon v: *anom* be; exist; become; **bið** *is* [pri3s]; **bēoð** *are* [pri3p]; **bēoð** *are* [prip]; **byþ** *is* [pri3s]; **biþ** *is* [pri3s]; **bið** [pri3s]; **bēoð** [prip]; **biþ** [pri3s]

be-wefan v: *strong6* cover over; envelope; **bewefen** *covering over* [ppa]

blōd n: *n strong* blood; **blōd** [ns]

brægen n: *n strong* brain; **brægen** [ns]

brēost-þing n: *n strong* breast; area around the chest and heart; **brēost-þing** [ns]

būtan prep: (+dat) without; except; **būtan** *without*

byrþor n: *n strong* fetus'; **byrþres** [ns]

cennan v: *pret-pres* to give birth; **cennan** [i]

cuþ adj: known; revealed; apparent; **cūð** [psmds]

cwic adj: alive (quick); **cwica** *alive* [pwmns]

eahtoþa adj: eighth; **eahtoþan** [pwmds]

eal adj: all; entirely; **eall** [psmns]

feorh n: *n strong* life; **feore** [ds]

feorh-ādl n: *f strong* fatal disease; life-sickness; **feorh-ādle** [ds]

feorþa adj: fourth; **feorþan** [pwmds]

fifta adj: fifth; **fiftan** [pwmds]

finger n: *m strong* fingers; **fingras** [np]

flōwan v: *strong7* flow; issue; **flōweð** *flows* [pri3s]

for prep: (+dat) for; because of; before; in; in the face of; in the presence of; as; though; **for**

fōt n: *m i-mut* foot; **fēt** *feet* [as]

ġearwian v: *weak2* equip; prepare; construct; make ready; **ġearwað** *prepares* [pri3s]

ġe-cynd n: *n i-mut* birth; **ġe-cynde** [ds]

ġe-dīgan v: *weak1* survives; endures; **ġe-dīgð** [pri3s]

ġe-hȳden v: *weak1* furnished with skin; **ġe-hȳd** [ppa]

ġe-settan v: *weak1* set; established; created; made; **ġe-seted** [ppa]

ġe-weorþan v: *strong3* be; be made; become; happen; impers. with acc. To happen; come to pass; befall; come together; agree; be agreeable; **ġe-wyrðeð** *becomes* [pri3s]; **ġe-worden** *developed* [ppa]; **on** *in* [ppa]

ġif conj: if; **ġif**

handa n: *f u* hand; **handa** *hands* [dp]

hē pron: *pers* he; **hē** [psn]

heorte n: *f strong* heart; **heorte** [ns]

hēr adv: here; **hēr** [p]

hī pron: *pers* they; **hī** [ppln]

him pron: *pers* him; **him** [psd]

hire pron: *pers* her; **hire** [psg]; **hyre** [psg]; **hire** [psd]

his pron: *pers* his; **his** [psg]

hit pron: *pers* it; **hit** [psa]

hū conj: how; **hū**

hwæþer conj: whether; **hwæþer**

inooþe n: *m strong* womb; inside; **innoþe** [ds]; **innoþe** *womb* [ds]

leng adj: longer; **lengran** [cwnap]

līċ n: *n strong* body; **līċ** [ns]

līcgan v: *strong5* lie; lie down; recline; lie prostrate; **līð** *lies* [pri3s]

lim n: *n strong* limb; joint; **limum** *limbs* [ds]

limpan v: *strong3* happen; occur; befall; come to pass; take place; **ġe-limpð** *happens* [pri3s]

maga n: *f strong* womb; **magan** [ds]

magan v: *pret-pres* are able; **magon** [paip]

manigġ-feald adj: manifold; numerous; **manigġ-feald** *manifold* [psnns]

mann n: *m i-mut* man; person; human being; **mannes** *human being's* [gs]; **man** *person* [dp]; **man** *man* [as]

mid prep: (+dat) with; together with; amid; among; by; by means of; through; **mid** *with*

mōdor n: *f r* mother; mother's; **mōdor** *mother's* [gs]; **mōder** [gs]; **modor** [ns]

mōnaþ n: *m strong* month; **mōnþe** [ds]; **on** [ds]

ne adv: not; **ne** [p]

niġoþa adj: ninth; **niġoþan** [pwmds]

oft adv: most often; **oftost** [s]

on prep: (+acc) on; onto; in; into; to; at against; during; among; amid; for; as; with; according to; **on** *into*; **on**

on prep: (+dat) on; onto; in; into; to; at against; during; among; amid; for; as; with; according to; **on** *in*; **on**; **on** *into*; **in**

ond conj: and; **ond**

on-ġinnan v: *strong3* begin; **on-ginð** [prip]

ōþer adj: second; **ōðrum** [psnds]

rēama n: *m weak* membrane; ligament; **rēoman** *membrane* [ns]

ribb n: *n strong* rib; **ribb** *ribs* [np]

sāwol n: *f strong* soul; the animal life; a human creature (after death); **sāwle** *soul* [gs]

scort adj: shorter; **scytran** [cwfap]

scypian v: *strong6* forming; taking shape; **scypiġende** [pri3s]

secgan v: *weak3* to say; tell; relate; describe; **secgan** *to tell* [i]

sēo det: *?* the; **sēo** [dns]

seofoþa adj: seventh; **seofoþan** [pwmds]

staþol-fæst adj: steadfast; firm; fixed; **staþol-fæst** *firm* [psfnp]

staþol-fæstlīċe adv: firmly; securely; **staþol-fæstlīċe** [p]

syxta adj: sixth; **syxtan** [pwfgs]; **syxtan** [pwmds]

tā n: *f weak* toes; **tān** [np]

Tīwes-niht n: *f strong* Monday night; **tīwes-niht** [ds]

tō prep: (+dat) to; as; **tō**

tō-dǣlan v: *weak1* disperse; separate; divide; **tō-dǣlede** *devided* [pai3s]; **tō-dǣled** *divided* [ppa]

tō-somne adv: together; **tō-somne** [p]

þā det: *?* the; **þā** [dnp]; **þā** [dap]

þām det: *?* the; **þām** [dds]

þǣr adv: there; **þǣr** [p]

þǣre det: *?* the; **þǣre** [dgs]

þæs det: *?* the; **þæs** [dgs]

þæt det: *?* the; **þæt** [dns]

þonne adv: then; **þonne** [p]

þonne conj: then; **þonne**

þridda adj: third; **þriddum** [psmds]

uppan prep: (+dat) up; onto; **uppan** *up*

ūtan adv: from without; on the outside; on the surface; outwardly; with ymb or be and verbs of motion or rest; about; round; out; away from land; **ūtan** *on the outside* [p]

weaxan v: *strong7* grow; be produced; grow up; increase; wax; grow in honour; grow great; flourish; prosper; be productive; take shape; **weaxeð** *grows* [pri3s]; **weaxende** [ppr]

weorþan v: *strong3* is; becomes; **wyrð** [pri3s]

wīf n: *n strong* women; woman; **wīfum** [dp]; **wīf** [ns]

witlēas adj: witless; mad; insane; unconscious?; **witlēas** *witless* [psfns]

witodlīċe adv: certainly; **witodlīċe** [p]

wuca n: *f weak* week; **wucan** [gs]

ymbe prep: (+dat) about; concerning; by; **ymbe** *about*